

CMP-05 · COMPETENCY FRAMEWORKS

PML-AI: the twenty-four competencies

Each competency of the PCI Project Management Leader – AI — defined, levelled, evidenced, and separated from its look-alike

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

The PCI Project Management Leader – AI credential publishes twenty-four competencies, the widest of the three sets. This document takes each one in turn and states what it is in terms of decisions, what it looks like at each of the four levels, the named artefacts that evidence it, and the common false positive — the thing that is routinely mistaken for the competency and is not it.

— About this document

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PML-AI: the twenty-four competencies

from its look-alike.

In one paragraph. The PCI Project Management Leader – AI credential publishes twenty-four competencies, the widest of the three PCI sets. This document takes each one in turn and states what it is in terms of decisions, what it looks like at each of the four levels, the named artefacts that evidence it, and the common false positive — the thing routinely mistaken for the competency and which is not it. It is the working reference for anyone assembling evidence, specifying a delivery role, or assessing a claim against the PML-AI standard.

Who this is for. Candidates for PML-AI; delivery directors, programme managers and heads of project management office designing roles and development plans; assessors applying the standard to evidence they did not collect.

— 1. How to read this document

The twenty-four competencies below are the published PML-AI set, in the published order, unaltered. Each entry follows the structure in CMP-01 §3: **definition**, **by level** (the scale is defined in CMP-02 §2 and not restated), **evidence**, and **the false positive**.

Two notes on the text itself. First, **no examination blueprint has been published for PML-AI** — no domain weightings, no item counts [**CONFIRM: PML-AI examination blueprint — weightings and item counts**]. This set is the authoritative statement of what the credential claims; it is not a weighted syllabus. Second, the platform stores competency 16 as Benefits realization; this framework is written in British English and renders it benefits realisation. Same competency, spelling only.

Breadth is the defining feature of this set: it runs from initiation to closure and across three delivery approaches. Breadth is not difficulty — see CMP-01 §2. It does mean that no realistic candidate is at leader level across twenty-four competencies, and a portfolio claiming otherwise reads as a portfolio that has not been thought about.

Acronyms are expanded on first use: project management office (PMO), work breakdown structure (WBS), critical path method (CPM), request for proposal (RFP), key performance indicator (KPI), estimate at completion (EAC).

— 2. Leading and framing the project

2.1 Project management

Definition. Running a project as an integrated system rather than a set of parallel activities: holding scope, schedule, cost, risk, quality and resource in a single coherent position, and making the trade-off explicit when one has to move.

By level. Foundation — executes assigned elements to plan and reports status accurately. Practitioner — manages a project or workstream end to end within an established method, and keeps the integrated position current. Professional — manages a project whose method must be chosen rather than inherited, and makes trade-offs visible to decision-makers as options with consequences rather than as requests for more time. Leader — sets how projects are run across an organisation, and owns the outcome when the method proves inadequate.

Evidence. A project management plan you authored with the integration between elements visible; a trade-off paper presenting options with consequences and the decision taken; a recovery plan for a project you inherited in difficulty, with the diagnosis.

The false positive. Coordination. Running meetings, chasing actions and consolidating other people's status is administration performed capably. The competency shows at the trade-off: when scope, cost and date cannot all hold, does this person present the choice clearly enough for someone to make it?

2.2 Project leadership

Definition. Getting a group of people who do not report to you to do difficult work in a specified direction — setting a direction people can act on, making decisions with incomplete information, absorbing pressure without transmitting panic, and being the person who says the unwelcome thing first. Depth in CMP-09.

By level. Foundation — works effectively within a team and raises issues candidly. Practitioner — leads a small team through routine delivery; communicates direction and makes decisions inside their scope. Professional — leads a project team through genuine difficulty: names the problem before it is obvious, holds an unpopular position where the evidence supports it, and changes position publicly when it does not. Leader — builds delivery leadership in others, sets the culture in which bad news travels quickly, and is accountable for what the team could not say.

Evidence. A decision made under uncertainty with the reasoning recorded at the time; an escalation you initiated that was unwelcome; a team you developed, with what changed; a project you stopped or recommended stopping.

The false positive. Seniority and span of control. Managing thirty people is a resourcing fact. Leadership evidence involves a moment where the leader carried a cost — reputational, political or personal — for a position that turned out to be right, or wrong and honestly owned.

2.3 Project initiation

Definition. Establishing a project properly before work starts: the objective, the scope boundary, the sponsor and governance, the success criteria, the assumptions and constraints, the initial funding and the authority to proceed — captured in a charter someone has actually signed.

By level. Foundation — prepares initiation documentation from provided inputs. Practitioner — runs initiation for a project: assembles the charter, identifies stakeholders, establishes the governance and secures approval. Professional — challenges the premise at initiation: tests whether the stated objective is the real objective, whether success criteria are measurable, and whether the sponsor has the authority the project will need. Refuses to start on an unresolvable ambiguity. Leader — sets initiation standards, and stops projects at the gate rather than after twelve months of spending.

Evidence. A charter you authored, with measurable success criteria and named assumptions; a documented challenge at initiation that changed the scope or the sponsor; an initiation gate you failed a project at, with reasons.

The false positive. Document production. A complete charter pack assembled from a template records that the process ran. The competency is the challenge: what did you ask at initiation that changed something?

2.4 Business cases

Definition. Building or testing the case for investment: the problem, the options considered, the costs and benefits with their bases, the risks, the assumptions the case depends on, and the point at which the case stops being true.

By level. Foundation — compiles inputs and checks internal consistency. Practitioner — prepares a business case to the organisation's standard, including option comparison and financial analysis. Professional — challenges the numbers in a case, including their own: tests whether the benefit is attributable to the project, whether the counterfactual is honest, whether the cost base is complete, and states the conditions under which the case fails. Leader — sets the standard for cases, and requires post-implementation comparison of claimed to realised benefit, which is where optimism gets priced.

Evidence. A case you authored with option comparison, benefit attribution and stated break conditions; a challenge you made to another party's case, with the change that followed; a post-implementation review comparing claimed to realised benefits.

The false positive. Assembling the case document. The competency is in benefit attribution — whether the benefit would have occurred anyway, whether it is double-counted elsewhere, and whether anybody has agreed to be accountable for delivering it.

2.5 Governance

Definition. Deciding who decides: the decision rights, the thresholds at which authority changes hands, the forums and their real remits, the reporting that feeds them, and the assurance that tests whether the reporting is true.

By level. Foundation — operates within the governance framework and prepares papers to standard. Practitioner — runs a governance cycle: schedules gates, prepares decision papers, tracks decisions and follows through on actions. Professional — designs governance for a project: right-sizes the forums, sets thresholds that reflect real risk, ensures decisions are made by people who can carry them, and removes bodies that consume effort without deciding anything. Leader — governs the governance across a portfolio, including the willingness to dissolve a committee and the discipline of assurance that is genuinely independent.

Evidence. A governance framework you designed, with decision rights and thresholds; decision records where the forum actually chose between options; an assurance review you commissioned or acted on; a governance body you disbanded and why.

The false positive. Chairing meetings. A well-attended steering committee that receives updates and approves what has already happened is a ceremony. The test is whether the governance has changed a decision in the last six months — and whether anyone can name it.

2.6 Scope and requirements

Definition. Establishing what the project will and will not deliver, in terms specific enough to be verified: requirements elicitation and specification, traceability from need to deliverable, the scope boundary and its exclusions, and the discipline that keeps additions visible.

By level. Foundation — documents requirements accurately and maintains traceability records. Practitioner — elicits and specifies requirements for a scope, builds a WBS that decomposes the work completely, and manages the requirements baseline. Professional — resolves conflicting requirements between stakeholders, decides what is out of scope and defends the exclusion, and specifies acceptance criteria that will not be arguable at handover. Leader — sets requirements and scope standards, and carries the consequence when a scope boundary proves wrong.

Evidence. A requirements specification with acceptance criteria and traceability; a WBS and dictionary you authored; a documented exclusion that held under pressure; a requirements conflict you resolved, with the decision basis.

The false positive. Requirements volume. Four hundred requirements, untraced and untestable, is a document. The competency shows in acceptance criteria — whether it will be possible to say objectively, at handover, that a requirement was met.

— 3. Delivering the work

3.1 Planning and execution

Definition. Turning scope into a credible plan and then running it: sequence and dependency, resource and capacity, milestone architecture, the update cycle, and the response when the plan and reality diverge. Depth in CMP-07.

By level. Foundation — plans and executes assigned work, and reports variance honestly. Practitioner — builds and runs the plan for a project or workstream, maintains it through change, and explains variance in terms of cause. Professional — designs the planning approach for the work in hand, decides the level of planning detail that is useful rather than impressive, and replans deliberately when the plan stops being a description of what will happen. Leader — sets planning standards, and enforces the distinction between a plan and a target.

Evidence. A plan you built with its basis documented; a replan with the trigger, the options and the decision; a milestone architecture that survived contact with delivery; a variance analysis whose diagnosis was later confirmed.

The false positive. Plan detail. A twelve-thousand-line schedule maintained fortnightly may be an expensive record of the past. The test is whether the plan is used to make decisions, and whether anyone can say what it currently predicts and why.

3.2 Stakeholder leadership

Definition. Identifying who can affect or is affected by the project, understanding what each actually needs as opposed to what they ask for, and managing the relationships so that decisions get made and commitments hold. Depth in CMP-09.

By level. Foundation — communicates clearly and maintains stakeholder records. Practitioner — runs stakeholder engagement for a scope: maps interests and influence, tailors communication,

and manages routine expectation. Professional — handles conflict between powerful stakeholders with incompatible objectives: surfaces the conflict rather than absorbing it, and brings it to a forum that can resolve it. Says no to a stakeholder who matters, and keeps the relationship. Leader — owns the organisation's most difficult delivery relationships and builds the capability in others.

Evidence. A stakeholder analysis with influence and interest, and what you did differently as a result; a conflict you surfaced and how it was resolved; a documented refusal to a senior stakeholder and the subsequent relationship; a communication regime you designed and the behaviour it changed.

The false positive. The stakeholder register. A matrix of names, categories and colour codes is an artefact that took an afternoon. The competency is visible in a conversation nobody wanted to have.

3.3 Procurement

Definition. Deciding what to buy and from whom: make-or-buy and packaging strategy, market engagement, specification and tender documentation, evaluation criteria and their application, and the transition from award into delivery.

By level. Foundation — supports procurement processes and maintains documentation. Practitioner — runs a procurement to process: prepares the RFP, manages the tender period, applies the evaluation model and documents the award. Professional — decides packaging strategy — how work is split into contracts and where the interface risk consequently sits — and designs evaluation criteria that select for what the project needs rather than for the best proposal writer. Leader — sets procurement strategy across a portfolio, owning the supply-market consequences of it.

Evidence. A packaging strategy with the interface implications analysed; an evaluation model you designed, with weighting rationale; a tender you ran end to end with the award recommendation; a post-award review of whether the evaluation predicted performance.

The false positive. Process compliance. Running a compliant tender is necessary and is not the competency. The competency is packaging and evaluation design — the two decisions taken before the process starts that determine whether the right supplier can win.

3.4 Contracts and commercial delivery

Definition. Managing the contract after award so the commercial position stays defensible: obligations and notices, change and variation, payment and valuation, performance regimes, and the record that substantiates entitlement. Depth in CMP-06.

By level. Foundation — administers contract processes and maintains records. Practitioner — manages contract delivery for a scope: issues notices in time, values changes, maintains the commercial register and applies the performance regime. Professional — decides the commercial position on contested matters: what to concede, what to reserve, what to disclose as exposure; assembles the contemporaneous record; and manages the interface with legal and commercial functions without outsourcing the judgement. Leader — sets commercial delivery standards and owns aggregate exposure.

Evidence. A change control log with the trail from instruction to agreed value; a notice issued within a time-bar and the entitlement it preserved; an exposure report separating forecast from unquantified exposure; a negotiated settlement with the basis recorded.

The false positive. Contract knowledge without record discipline. Being able to cite the mechanism does not substantiate a claim eighteen months later. The competency is whether the daily records, the delay evidence and the correspondence exist and are organised.

3.5 Cost, schedule and risk integration

Definition. Holding cost, schedule and risk as one position rather than three reports: a schedule that reconciles to the cost forecast, risk exposure that reconciles to contingency, and a change that moves all three consistently.

By level. Foundation — produces the three sets of data accurately. Practitioner — reconciles them for a scope and identifies inconsistencies between forecasts. Professional — designs the integration: common breakdown structures, a single change process affecting all three, contingency draw-down tied to risk retirement, and an EAC that reflects the schedule position rather than contradicting it. Leader — requires integration across a portfolio and refuses reporting that presents the three positions as independent.

Evidence. A reconciliation between schedule forecast and cost forecast, with the differences explained; a contingency drawdown analysis tied to risk retirement; an integrated change control process you designed; a case where you identified that the three positions could not all be true.

The false positive. Three reports in one pack. Physical adjacency is not integration. The diagnostic question: if the schedule slips two months, does the cost forecast move — automatically, traceably, and by an amount someone can explain?

3.6 Predictive delivery

Definition. Delivering under a plan-driven approach: a defined scope baselined up front, CPM scheduling, baseline change control, and progress measured against the plan. The competency includes knowing the conditions under which the approach works — stable requirements, understood technology — and recognising when those conditions are absent.

By level. Foundation — works within a baselined plan and reports progress against it. Practitioner — runs predictive delivery for a scope: maintains the baseline, controls change, and measures progress with defined rules of credit. Professional — decides when predictive delivery is the right approach and defends the baseline against uncontrolled change, while recognising when the baseline has become fiction and requiring a rebaseline rather than managing to a plan nobody believes. Leader — sets the standard for baseline integrity and decides when a portfolio's approach must change.

Evidence. A baseline you established with its change control regime; a rebaseline you recommended, with the trigger and the analysis; a progress measurement regime with rules of credit; a change you refused and why.

The false positive. Defending an obsolete baseline. Rigour and rigidity look identical from outside and are opposite competencies. The distinguishing test is whether the person has ever concluded that their own baseline no longer represented the work, and said so.

3.7 Agile delivery

Definition. Delivering iteratively against an ordered backlog with working increments, empirical progress measurement and short feedback cycles — and knowing what the approach requires to

function: an available decision-maker, a genuinely ordered backlog, a real definition of done, and the organisational willingness to change scope rather than date.

By level. Foundation — works within an agile team and understands the events and artefacts. Practitioner — runs or facilitates delivery for a team: maintains the backlog, protects the increment, measures throughput, and surfaces impediments. Professional — establishes agile delivery where it does not yet function: secures a decision-maker with real authority, insists on a definition of done that includes the parts nobody enjoys, and reports empirical forecast ranges rather than commitments the data does not support. Leader — decides where the organisation delivers this way and changes the surrounding governance and funding to make it possible.

Evidence. Throughput or cycle-time data with the forecast you derived and the outturn; a definition of done you established and enforced; an impediment escalated to and resolved at organisational level; a backlog ordering decision that cost a stakeholder something.

The false positive. Ceremonies. Running stand-ups, retrospectives and a board is a process performed. The competency test: can the team release, does the definition of done include testing and documentation, and does anyone act on the empirical data — or is the date still fixed and the scope still fixed?

3.8 Hybrid delivery

Definition. Combining predictive and adaptive approaches in one delivery where the work genuinely differs — typically a fixed-date, fixed-interface infrastructure element alongside iteratively developed software or process — and designing the joints: integration points, a common reporting position, and one governance forum that can read both.

By level. Foundation — works within a hybrid arrangement and understands both cadences. Practitioner — operates across both: maintains a plan for the predictive elements and a backlog for the adaptive ones, and manages the dependencies between them. Professional — designs the hybrid: decides which parts are which, defines the interface contract between them, and creates a single integrated reporting position rather than two incompatible ones. Leader — sets the organisation's approach and resolves the funding and governance mismatch that hybrids always expose.

Evidence. A delivery approach decision with the reasoning per element; an interface or dependency management design between cadences; an integrated report both audiences accepted; a governance forum that worked across both.

The false positive. Method mixing without design. "We're agile within a stage gate" often means neither approach functioning: no baseline integrity and no empirical measurement. Hybrid competence is visible in the joint, and the joint is a designed artefact.

3.9 Quality and change management

Definition. Two connected disciplines: assuring that what is delivered meets the specification (quality planning, assurance, control, acceptance and defect management), and controlling changes to what was agreed (change assessment, authority, and traceability into scope, cost, schedule and risk).

By level. Foundation — applies quality procedures and records changes accurately. Practitioner — runs quality control and change control for a scope: inspection and test regimes, defect tracking, change assessment and approval routing. Professional — designs both for a project: what is assured versus inspected, acceptance criteria that will hold at handover, and a change process that

makes the cumulative effect of small changes visible rather than letting it accumulate invisibly. Leader — sets quality and change standards, and owns the cost of quality as a managed number.

Evidence. A quality plan distinguishing assurance from control; a defect trend with the intervention and its effect; a change register showing cumulative impact against the original baseline; a rejected change with its assessment.

The false positive. Change log volume. A complete register that nobody aggregates hides the number that matters — the cumulative movement from the original position. The competency shows in the aggregate view, and in whether anyone has ever been surprised by it.

— 4. Value, closure and the AI group

4.1 Benefits realisation

Definition. Ensuring the project produces the outcome it was funded for: defining benefits so they can be measured, assigning ownership to people who can influence them, establishing the baseline before the change, and measuring after handover — including when the answer is unwelcome.

By level. Foundation — collects benefit measurement data as defined. Practitioner — maintains the benefits profile, tracks measures and reports realisation. Professional — defines benefits so that realisation is falsifiable: metric, baseline, measurement method, owner and date; separates project outputs from business outcomes; and reports shortfall honestly. Leader — holds the organisation to post-implementation measurement, and feeds the result back into how future cases are appraised.

Evidence. A benefits profile with baselines captured before the change; a post-implementation review comparing claimed to realised, including a shortfall; a benefit you reclassified as unattributable; a change to business case standards driven by realisation data.

The false positive. Benefit declaration at closure. Stating in the closure report that benefits will be realised, and then dissolving the team, is the standard failure across the discipline. The competency requires a measurement that happened after the project ended, and a named person who owned the number.

4.2 Sustainability

Definition. Managing the environmental and social dimensions of delivery as a delivery matter: whole-life impact in design and option choice, emissions and resource use during execution, ethical and responsible supply chain, community and workforce effects, and the legacy or handback condition of the asset.

By level. Foundation — complies with requirements and records data accurately. Practitioner — implements the plan: monitors and reports indicators, applies supply-chain requirements, and manages community obligations. Professional — integrates sustainability into decisions rather than reporting: brings whole-life impact into option selection, sets supply-chain requirements that change what is bought, and states the trade-off with cost and programme explicitly instead of asserting there isn't one. Leader — sets the organisation's delivery standard and accepts the cost consequences.

Evidence. An option analysis where an impact assessment changed the selection; supply-chain requirements you specified and their effect on procurement; a measurement regime with data and outcomes; a handback or legacy plan you authored.

The false positive. Reporting against indicators. Collecting and publishing data is measurement. The competency is whether a decision came out differently — and if none did, the sustainability work was reporting.

4.3 Project closure

Definition. Ending a project properly: completing and accepting deliverables, closing contracts and resolving final accounts, transferring the asset and its operating knowledge, releasing resources, archiving records so they are retrievable, and capturing lessons in a form somebody will use.

By level. Foundation — completes closure tasks and documentation. Practitioner — runs closure for a scope: acceptance, contract closeout, handover documentation and archive. Professional — manages contested closure: disputed final accounts, incomplete acceptance, an operator unwilling to receive the asset — and closes it rather than letting it drift into a maintenance backlog. Ensures lessons are specific enough to act on. Leader — sets closure standards and prevents the organisational habit of leaving projects ninety-five per cent closed indefinitely.

Evidence. A closure report with acceptance status, final account position and outstanding items; a disputed final account you settled, with the basis; a handover and training package the operator accepted; a lesson that changed a subsequent project, traceably.

The false positive. The closure report. A completed template records that a process ran. The competency is visible in the hard closures — the contract with an unresolved claim, the operator who did not want the asset — and in whether any lesson was ever adopted.

4.4 AI-enabled project management

Definition. Designing how delivery management uses artificial intelligence: which tasks are delegated (status synthesis, risk identification prompts, document drafting, schedule analysis, meeting capture), what the model receives, where its output enters the management process, and what check stands between that output and a decision. Depth in CMP-08.

By level. Foundation — uses approved tools within the defined process and checks output before use. Practitioner — operates AI-assisted workflows end to end and recognises implausible output. Professional — designs the workflow: task selection, input and output specification, the check, and the tasks that are excluded — usually the ones involving a judgement someone must own. Leader — sets the delivery function's AI operating model, admits tools, and decides where the organisation will not use AI.

Evidence. A process map showing assisted steps with check points; a tool evaluation with criteria and decision; a task removed from an assisted workflow and why; an incident review after AI output reached a decision.

The false positive. Tool adoption. The competency is the design — where output enters, and what would catch it if it were confidently wrong.

4.5 Decision intelligence

Definition. Improving how decisions are actually made: framing the decision and its options, defining what evidence would change the answer, using analysis proportionate to the stakes, guarding against the predictable biases of a delivery environment, and recording the decision with its basis so it can be reviewed later.

By level. Foundation — prepares decision inputs accurately and completely. Practitioner — structures decisions for a forum: options, criteria, evidence, recommendation, and a decision record. Professional — designs the decision process for consequential choices: identifies the decision-maker, frames genuine alternatives rather than one option and two straw men, names what would falsify the recommendation, and applies analysis proportionate to the stakes. Leader — sets decision standards across a portfolio, and requires periodic review of past decisions against outcomes.

Evidence. A decision paper with genuine alternatives and falsification conditions; a decision record with basis and assumptions, later reviewed against outcome; a decision you reopened when an assumption failed; a bias you designed against and the mechanism you used.

The false positive. Analytical volume. A hundred-page options appraisal supporting a foregone conclusion is elaborate ratification. The competency test: did the analysis have a realistic chance of producing a different answer, and has this person ever changed their recommendation because of it?

4.6 Digital delivery

Definition. Running delivery on a coherent digital toolchain: which system holds each data item, how they connect, how status flows from source to report without manual re-keying, and how the resulting record is retained and retrievable.

By level. Foundation — uses the toolchain correctly and maintains data quality in their scope. Practitioner — administers delivery tooling: configures workflows, maintains integrations, resolves discrepancies between systems. Professional — designs the delivery information architecture: source of truth per item, integration points, definitions agreed across functions, and the deliberate removal of duplicate systems. Leader — sets the standard across the portfolio, including data retention, and resolves the political problem that every function prefers its own system.

Evidence. An information architecture or data-flow map you produced; an integration that removed manual re-keying, with the error rate before and after; a duplicate system you retired; a data definition dispute you resolved.

The false positive. Tool count. A rich estate of poorly connected tools produces more reconciliation work than the manual process it replaced. The competency is in the architecture — one source per item, and lineage that survives an audit.

4.7 Automation

Definition. Removing manual steps from the delivery management cycle without removing the control: deciding what to automate, designing so failures are loud rather than silent, and maintaining it as surrounding systems change. Shared in substance with the PCL-AI competency of the same name; see CMP-08 §5.

By level. Foundation — runs automated routines and reports failures. Practitioner — builds and maintains automation for a defined task with error handling and a reconciliation that proves the

output. Professional — decides what should and should not be automated on frequency, stability and the cost of a silent error; builds break-detection; documents it so it survives the author. Leader — sets the automation standard including ownership, change control and the prohibition on single-person dependencies.

Evidence. An automated process with documentation, error handling and reconciliation; a break you designed that later caught a real failure; a decision not to automate, with reasoning; a handover in which someone else took the automation over.

The false positive. Script count. Automation that fails silently and produces a plausible wrong number increases risk while appearing to increase efficiency. When this breaks, how will anyone know?

4.8 Responsible AI

Definition. Governing AI use in delivery: what project, personal and commercial data may enter which tool; where AI-derived material must be disclosed to a board, a client or a supplier; how bias is considered where models touch people — resourcing, performance, supplier evaluation; and which uses are prohibited.

By level. Foundation — follows policy, particularly on confidential and personal data. Practitioner — applies it in live delivery, discloses assistance where required, and escalates unexplainable output. Professional — sets the project position: permitted uses, data handling, disclosure convention, and explainability as a condition of reliance rather than a preference. Leader — owns the governance framework, procurement criteria and incident handling, and prohibits uses the organisation would find convenient.

Evidence. A project-level AI use position you authored; a disclosure convention adopted in reporting; a documented prohibition with rationale; an incident review with the control change that followed.

The false positive. Policy possession. The evidence is a decision that cost something — a tool not adopted, a use case declined, a disclosure that invited a difficult question. AIG-08 and AIG-09 own the underlying framework.

4.9 Human accountability

Definition. The named person who answers for a decision or a deliverable, including one produced with AI assistance or by an automated process, and including work they did not personally perform. Broader than the PCL-AI and PFL-AI competency human validation: validation is the act of checking; accountability is the standing answerability for the outcome and the design of a system in which someone is always answerable.

By level. Foundation — takes responsibility for their own work, including its errors, and does not attribute an output to a tool. Practitioner — owns delegated and assisted outputs within their scope: checks what must be checked, and answers for what they release. Professional — designs accountability into a workflow so no output reaches a decision without a named owner; refuses to release output they cannot stand behind; and does not deflect to "the system said". Leader — ensures the delivery organisation has no accountability gaps — no decision taken by a process with no owner — and answers for failures of that design personally.

Evidence. An accountability map for a workflow, with named owners per output; a decision you owned whose analysis was produced by a model or a team, including how you satisfied yourself; a

case where you declined to release output you could not stand behind; a post-incident review in which you owned a failure in a process you designed.

The false positive. Sign-off. A signature on a document produced by someone or something else, without a statement of what was checked, is a record of a signature. The house position is that AI proposes and the professional disposes: disposal means a person is answerable, by name, when it is wrong.

— 5. Where the boundaries actually lie

Project management and project leadership. The first is the integrated system of scope, cost, schedule and risk; the second is what makes people act. Strong evidence for one is routinely offered for the other, and it does not transfer.

Governance and project management. Governance decides who decides; project management operates within those decision rights. A person who has designed governance has done something different from a person who has followed it well.

Predictive, agile and hybrid delivery. Three distinct competencies, not one spectrum. The most common gap is a candidate strong in one, describing the other two in vocabulary rather than in decisions.

Business cases and benefits realisation. The case forecasts benefit; realisation measures it after handover. Almost every portfolio has evidence of the first; the second is where candidates separate.

Human accountability and human validation. Validation is the act of checking (see CMP-03 §3.6 and CMP-04 §4.5). Accountability is answering for the outcome, including for checks performed by others.

— 6. How this goes wrong

Twenty-four competencies, twenty-four leader-level claims. Immediately implausible, and it devalues the claims that were true. Breadth is the property of the set, not of the individual.

One project supplies all the evidence. A single large project can legitimately evidence many competencies, but if every artefact carries the same project name and the same two years, the portfolio demonstrates a role rather than a repertoire. Show a second context, especially for the delivery-approach competencies.

Agile competence is evidenced by ceremonies and certificates. Evidence is throughput data with a forecast and an outturn, a definition of done that was enforced, and a decision that changed scope rather than date.

Predictive competence is evidenced by baseline defence alone. Defending a baseline is half the competency; recognising when the baseline has become fiction is the other half, and the harder half.

Hybrid delivery is claimed because both approaches are present in the organisation. Hybrid competence is the designed joint between them. If nobody designed the joint, there is no hybrid competence in the building.

Benefits realisation is evidenced by the business case. The case is a forecast. Realisation evidence happens after handover and frequently reports a shortfall. A portfolio in which every benefit was realised in full is not a strong portfolio; it is an unmeasured one.

Human accountability is evidenced by job title. Accountability is demonstrated at the moment something went wrong. If nothing in the portfolio ever went wrong, the portfolio is incomplete, not exemplary.

— 7. Checklist

For a candidate assembling evidence, or an assessor reviewing it:

- [] Have all twenty-four competencies been addressed, with honest levels including foundation?
 - [] Does the evidence span more than one project and more than one delivery approach?
 - [] For predictive: is there both baseline defence **and** a rebaseline judgement?
 - [] For agile: is there empirical data and an enforced definition of done, rather than ceremonies?
 - [] For hybrid: is there a designed interface between cadences, and one integrated report?
 - [] For governance: can you name a decision the governance changed?
 - [] For benefits: is there a measurement taken **after** handover, including a shortfall?
 - [] For business cases: is benefit attribution addressed, not just benefit totals?
 - [] For the AI competencies: is the evidence a decision — where output enters, what check, what excluded?
 - [] For human accountability: is there an instance of owning a failure, by name?
 - [] Is every artefact dated, with anything older than three years flagged as historical?
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— Related

- [CMP-01 – The PCI competency framework – overview](#) — what the set is for and how each entry is structured
- [CMP-02 – Competency levels and how they are evidenced](#) — the four-level scale used throughout
- [CMP-07 – Planning, scheduling and risk competencies in depth](#) — planning, integration and risk at working depth
- [CMP-08 – Data, digital and AI competencies in depth](#) — the AI chain from analysis to accountability
- [CMP-09 – Behavioural and leadership competencies](#) — leadership, stakeholder and accountability behaviours
- [CMP-10 – Assessing competence – evidence, rubrics and moderation](#) — how these claims are tested

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform certification catalogue ([backend/Data/MultiCert.cs](#)), verified August 2026 — the PML-AI seeded competency set, twenty-four items, reproduced here in the published order.

Competency 16 is stored as Benefits realization and is rendered benefits realisation in this British English text.

- [docs/books/pml-ai/COMPETENCY_MAP.md](#) — the PML-AI competency map, which records that all twenty-four published competencies are covered and that no examination blueprint exists.
- PCI Body of Knowledge domains 8, 9, 10, 11, 12 and 13 ([docs/bok/](#)) — cited by domain, not reproduced.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 — effective date to be confirmed · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.